



Standing out: Avinash Sable has been a standout performer in India's individual track events over the past Olympic cycle. GETTY IMAGES

Bahamas in May. India needs to finish in the top 14 teams at the World Relays to qualify directly for the Olympics. Although it could still qualify for Paris based on its rankings, it would probably want to book its tickets on the first attempt. The quartet of Muhammad Anas, Amoj Jacob, Muhammad Ajmal, and Rajesh Ramesh have broken the psychological barrier of three minutes (2:59.05) in the heats of the World Championships, where they almost managed to run down the mighty American team, and then once more in the final, where they finished a historic fifth. That result and a subsequent gold medal at the Asian Games would only have boosted their confidence to replicate their best run at Paris in half a year.

It's a testament to the meteoric

INDIA'S TRACK AND FIELD SURGE MAKES THE MEN'S RELAY TEAM JUST ONE OF MANY CAPTIVATING EVENTS FOR FANS

progression of Indian track and field that even a team as accomplished as the men's relay team would only be one of the many events for sports fans to focus on.

The Olympics are likely to throw up even bigger stars. Although Jeswin Aldrin has yet to qualify for the Olympics, the Indian national record holder in the men's long jump will always be considered one of the dark horses of the event, capable of pulling off a massive leap at any point in time. Women's javelin thrower Annu Rani might have had a

middling 2023 season but salvaged it with the third-ever best throw of her career (62.92m) to win gold at the Asian Games, beating, amongst others, the reigning Olympic champion. Annu hasn't yet qualified directly for the Olympics and might have to depend on her ranking to see her through.

She would back herself to recreate a moment of magic, as she did in Hangzhou last year, if she booked a place in her second Games at the age of 31.